

Making a splash: Sawan won gold and created a National Games record in men's 10000m at the 38th National Games in Dehradun last year.

RITU RAJ KONWAR

believe he could have done better.

"Sawan's goal before the race was to run at least 2:10:00 and even up to 2:09:00. But he was making his marathon debut. He didn't have the experience to deal with situations where the body tightens up at the end or when conditions change suddenly. The more he runs, the better he will get," Younis said.

Sawan says his immediate reaction after crossing the finish line was one of disappointment.

"I didn't feel excited when I completed the race and knew I had the national record. I only had this feeling of sadness that I wasn't able to meet my target of running 2:10:00. The people around me were excited. My coach was really happy, but I was only thinking of how the last two kilometres had gone," he says.

It was coach Markose who finally told Sawan to cheer up.

"He told me that for 48 years, so many people have been trying to do what I did. He said I didn't get it this time, but there's still a lot of time to do the 2:10 or 2:08 race, so I should just enjoy the moment," says Sawan.

Higher goals

With his current time, Sawan has met the Athletics Federation of India's qualification standard for the Asian Games (2:15:04).

He's already clear about his target.

"The goal is to win a medal at the Asian Games," he says.

A medal at the Games in Aichi-Nagoya will be a steep challenge. While each country's participation is capped at two runners, between China and Japan, there are some 105 runners who have already clocked faster times than Sawan's new national record this year. Three of those runners have gone below 2:06:09 this season.

And Sawan is not just thinking about the Asian Games.

"This year my goal is to perform at



the Asian Games, but I also want to qualify for the marathon at the Olympics in 2028," he says.

As significant as Rotterdam is, it is not enough. He knows this, too.

"It took nearly 50 years for the national record to come down from 2:12:00, but it shouldn't be at this level. I think the national record needs to be closer to the world standard. I know I can bring it down to less than 2:10:00, but I think the record should be around 2:05:00 or 2:06:00," he says. There is still heavy training ahead, kilometres to log and races to run before Sawan gets close to that mark. Training alone will not be enough.

"The more races I run, the more experience I'll get on how to deal with different situations in a marathon. However much we train, in the end, a marathon race is all about determination.

"Running at that pace for more than two hours is physically tiring but also mentally exhausting. When your legs become heavy, and your back

becomes tired, and even your mind wants to give up, you need to have something inside you to push yourself," he says.

Rotterdam, Sawan says, taught him he has that 'something'.

"A few months back, I put a wallpaper on my phone with the message — A strong mind changes everything. At my first marathon, I think I practised that. When I had about 800m to go, I started feeling I didn't have the energy to push myself. I kept telling myself I just have to finish.

"Even when I fell in the last 100 metres, my eyes were on the digital clock on the finish line. There was so much crowd around me, but I don't even remember looking at them. My eyes were just locked on that clock. The only thing I remember thinking was that I had to break the national record somehow. I think in the end, it was my mentality that took me over the finish line. I hope it will help me achieve bigger goals in the future," he says.